

The Logitech QuickCam Orbit MP

Is this Robert the Robot from Steve Zodiac's Fireball XL5? The Logitech QuickCam Orbit MP is a high-end webcam featuring motorised pan and tilt for face tracking, and looks just like a robot when its motorised drive is in action and the red LED near its lens is on.

The camera sports a pan of 189 degrees and a tilt of 102 degrees. So, unless you are trying your best to hide from it, it will keep you in focus. It also has multiple-face tracking, which means that if there are two subjects in the frame, it will try to keep both subjects in the frame! Needless to say, we had a good time foiling this feature—it does a commendable job though. The 9-inch stand that comes with the webcam lets you elevate it easily. The 1.3 MP sensor captures videos with very good image quality, and you can click still images at a quality as high as 4 MP.

This camera has RightLight and RightSound technologies built into it: these technologies need to be supported by your hardware and software drivers. RightLight enables you to view images in optimal

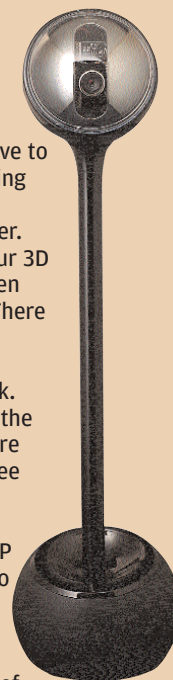
image colour, brightness, and contrast under a variety of different light conditions. Thus, the image always appears natural, as we noticed in our tests with this webcam.

RightSound technology enables you to voice-chat without the need for headphones. You can use your PC speakers to hear the other person, and the microphone is built into the Orbit MP. This is possible because the acoustic echo cancellation (AEC) featured in this technology identifies the sound waves produced by the speakers (sent by the other person), which the software then filters, preventing it from being sent back through the microphone. So you can prevent the disturbing feedback of sound—that loud, high-pitched squeal that usually occurs.

This camera features Logitech Video Effects, which enable you to personalise your on-screen appearance using Avatars and Face Accessories. Avatars are three-dimensionally rendered animated characters that mimic your facial movements and expressions, while Face Accessories are 2D images such as a

moustache, hats or sunglasses that are superimposed on your image. Before you start using this feature, you have to calibrate the Orbit MP using the software so that it recognises your face better. Thus, when you smile, your 3D Avatar will smile, and when you frown, it will frown! There are many 3D Avatars to choose from, such as the Dinosaur, Alien, and Shark. The software comes with the all these Avatars, and more can be downloaded for free after you register your purchase of the cam.

The QuickCam Orbit MP comes with a quality stereo headset and a 6-foot USB cable. It's expensive—Rs 10,200—but with the sheer abundance of features, this cam still doesn't seem overpriced.



A bird's eye view

On to the Notebook webcams: the Genius VideoCAM Messenger was found to capture the best visual details with better colour reproduction, brightness and contrast than the rest. The Logitech QuickCam for Notebooks Deluxe and QuickCam Image were also quite good.

Unlike the VideoCAM Messenger, the Genius VideoCAM Eye had the lowest video quality. We tried everything we could, but could not get it to focus on the subject, and the resulting image appeared blurred.

In Conclusion

At the end of the day, we took into account the Price, Features and Performance ratings to arrive at the winners.

We initially expected the big brands to leave with the accolades, but were in for a surprise. In the PC category, we had been a little apprehensive about the

Tech-Com SSD-641-MP, because it was from a much smaller brand than giants like Microsoft, Logitech, and Creative. The image quality of the Tech-Com SSD-641-MP wasn't the best, but it wasn't far from the leaders. However, at a rock-bottom price of just Rs 549, it's amazing! With-

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Logitech QuickCam Image
For Notebooks or for the PC?

out doubts, this webcam is the Digit Best Buy Gold—thanks to an amazing value for money score.

The other winner in the PC category was no surprise, however. With crystal clear image quality, digital zoom and panning, a high video resolution of 1.3 MP and a very high still photo resolution of 5 MP, the Microsoft LifeCam VX-6000 was adjudged the winner of the Digit Best Buy Silver, despite its high price of Rs 5,631.

Coming to the Notebook webcam category, the Genius VideoCAM Messenger was the best performer. It came with Mac support, digital zoom, and software that lets you add visual effect to live webcam video stream from the camera. Combine this with its ornamental good looks and a reasonably low price of Rs 1,500, and the Genius VideoCAM Messenger had to be the Digit Best Buy Gold winner.

The Logitech QuickCam Image was the only camera that came with a pedestal to turn it into a PC webcam. It was quite sleek and it had the second-best image quality in this category. Hence, though it was expensive at Rs 3,495, it still managed to bag the Digit Best Buy Silver award. ■

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Webcams

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